

ACTIVITY 4 — FACILITATOR GUIDE**PDCA Small Improvement Project Charter**

TYPE	DURATION	DMAIC PHASE
Elective Activity	45 min	DEFINE

Purpose of this activity

Charter a small improvement using PDCA with a measurable goal.

Not every improvement needs a full DMAIC project. Use PDCA to charter a small, fast improvement that a Yellow Belt can run under guidance — with a problem statement, a measurable goal and a defined check point.

What learners produce

A one-page PDCA charter with a solution-free problem statement, a measurable goal, an explicit in/out scope table and a stated decision rule.

Materials required

- Learner Worksheet (one per learner)
- Checklist (one per group)
- A laptop with Excel, Google Sheets or LibreOffice Calc
- The CSV files in this activity's data/ and templates/ folders
- Flipchart or A3 sheet and markers
- The course slides for the scenario and the framework

Set-up

Groups of 3-5. Distribute one worksheet per learner and one checklist per group. Every activity runs on the same continuous Contoso Service Desk scenario, so remind learners where this one sits in that story before starting.

Scenario / briefing material

Contoso Service Desk handles employee IT requests. Employees complain that tickets take too long to be assigned, that they must keep chasing for status, and that agents apply different definitions of what counts as "resolved". Handoffs between the front line and the specialist queues are unclear, and although ticket data exists it is inconsistent. You are supporting the improvement team as a Yellow Belt — you do not lead the project.

Two weeks of data have been collected: 400 tickets, of which 96 contained at least one defect, with 120 defects recorded in total across 6 defect opportunities per ticket. Mean assignment time is 55 minutes (median 46) against a 30-minute improvement goal. The CSV files in this activity's data/ folder are that extract.

Files in this activity folder

templates/ — the worksheets you complete:

- pdca-charter.csv (section, content)

Open these in Excel, Google Sheets or LibreOffice Calc. Work on a copy so the originals stay clean for revision.

Baseline figures for the goal statement come from data/daily-summary.csv.

How to run it — step by step

#	Instruction to learners	Facilitator note
1	Map the four PDCA phases to concrete actions for your scenario.	The single most common failure is a solution smuggled into the problem statement.
2	Write the problem statement: process, time period, measurable issue and impact — no solution.	Baselines must come from the data, not memory — send them to daily-summary.csv.
3	Write a measurable goal statement: metric, baseline, target and date.	If the goal has no date it is not a goal.
4	Define scope with an explicit in-scope / out-of-scope table to prevent scope creep.	
5	Identify stakeholders and the decision you will make after the Check phase.	
6	Confirm the improvement is small enough to test within two weeks.	

Suggested timing

Minutes	Phase
5 min	Map the four PDCA phases
12 min	Write the problem statement
10 min	Write a measurable goal statement
10 min	Define scope in and out
8 min	Identify stakeholders and the Check decision

Total: 45 minutes

Discussion & decision prompts

1. Does your problem statement name a cause or a solution anywhere? Remove it.
2. What would make you ABANDON rather than ADAPT the pilot?
3. Who must agree the scope before work starts?

Debrief

Bring the class back together and draw out the learning:

- Ask two or three groups to show what they produced, not just what they concluded.
- Ask what surprised them — the gap between what they assumed and what the data showed.
- Link the activity explicitly back to the DEFINE phase of DMAIC.
- Remind learners how this activity feeds the next phase of the improvement package.

Reflection questions:

- What small improvement could you charter at work within two weeks?
- Who would need to be in the room for it to stick?

Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- The single most common failure is a solution smuggled into the problem statement.
- Baselines must come from the data, not memory — send them to daily-summary.csv.
- If the goal has no date it is not a goal.

Success criterion

Your goal statement contains a metric, a baseline, a target and a date, and your problem statement names no solution.

How this fits the course

This activity builds the DEFINE phase of DMAIC. Every activity reuses the same techniques on the same Contoso Service Desk scenario and the same figures (400 tickets, yield 76%, DPMO 50,000), so the outputs accumulate into one improvement package. Nothing is practised here that is not taught in the slides.